



TEACHER Sylvia Loera works with children at a preschool on the Park Elementary campus in Alhambra.

ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

Empty schools become a fit for day care

Amid enrollment drops, campuses join with nonprofits to expand toddler spots.

By KATE SEQUEIRA

Declining enrollment in California public schools is spawning a new and growing partnership that is helping to keep child-care centers in business — vacant classrooms are being filled with toddlers and babies.

From Los Angeles to Solano counties, nonprofit day-care operators see underused facilities already centered on children — spacious blacktops with ample room for portables, empty classrooms and even entire closed campuses — as a way to expand services to families desperate for infant and toddler care, the 3-and-younger age group in which there are critical shortages of slots in California.

School districts, looking for ways to keep neighborhood campuses open amid dwindling enrollment, see future students in the little ones on site — and an opportunity to build family loyalty without having to operate the programs themselves.

“The school, it’s a very trusted place for the communities,” Early Edge Executive Director Patricia Lozano said. “If we can add all these elements ... I think it’s just making it more accessible.”

Recently, centers have

[See **Child care**, A7]

Single drivers penalized in insurance market

By LAURENCE DARMIENTO

California has long been known as a progressive state that embraces evolving lifestyles, but when it comes to auto insurance, it seems stuck in the 1950s.

Single, divorced or widowed and need coverage for your car? You very well might pay more than your married neighbor — a penalty sanctioned by the state and judiciary.

A California appeals court last month upheld a lower court ruling that rejected a lawsuit seeking to abolish the right of insurers to charge the unwed more because of their higher statistical chance of getting into crashes. The decision is expected to be appealed.

The lawsuit by 11 unmarried drivers specifically sought a court order that would have forced Insurance Commissioner Ricardo Lara to eliminate marriage as an optional factor in setting rates, but he opposed it, even as regulators bar the consideration of sex, age, race and other personal characteristics.

“This is really a question about whether the insurance commissioner has the ability to pick and choose what civil rights laws are appropriate to enforce,” said Christian Schreiber, who is among several attorneys representing the drivers who also have filed proposed class actions against 12 insurers over the rule.

A test conducted by the Consumer Federation of America, cited in a legal brief in support of the litigation, found that unmarried drivers pay more.

Single, divorced and widowed drivers got quotes in April 2025 that were up to \$108 higher for six months of premiums from four out of five California carriers.

Mercury, a large Los Angeles-based insurer, charged the highest differential, though it offered lower rates to widowed motorists with 34 or more years of driving experience. It declined to comment on the litigation.

State Farm, California’s largest auto insurer,

[See **Insurance**, A10]

Immigration law scams surge

People seeking legal help are falling victim to fraud

By ITZEL LUNA

In Orange County, an email landed in attorney Sabrina Rivera’s inbox in April, from a Colorado man panicked about the status of his immigration case.

He told Rivera that she was his lawyer. But Rivera had never heard his name before, never represented him and had no idea why he thought she had.

The man sent screenshots of his text conversations with someone claiming to be Rivera. Someone was using her name — and her state bar license number — to scam the man into believ-

ing she was representing him in his removal proceedings. He had paid the impostor at least \$700 since February, he told her.

Immigration law scams surged in the last year and a half, since the Trump administration’s crackdown resulted in thousands of new cases flooding the court system, attorneys and immigrant aid groups say.

The area of law has always been ripe for fraud, but the hustles have evolved, getting more sophisticated in the last year. Most recently, scammers have been taking on the identities of practicing attorneys.

Some rely on AI to gener-

ate realistic-looking attorney photos and websites. Other scammers take videos and photos from real practicing attorneys and overlay different audio to trick immigrants into sending them money.

Bar-licensed attorneys have also tried to fast-track the system, filing invalid asylum or lawful permanent residency applications for unknowing clients.

“It’s really the worst environment that I think anyone in the field has ever seen for taking advantage of people,” said Daniel Sharp, the chief of the Los Angeles County Office of Immigrant Affairs.

[See **Scams**, A5]

Holdout GOP senators now back Blanche

The acting attorney general’s order killing Trump’s \$1.8-billion fund precedes shift.

By BEN WIEDER

WASHINGTON — After experiencing some turbulence last week, Todd Blanche’s nomination to be attorney general appears to be back on course.

The acting attorney general released an order Sunday night officially declaring dead the nearly \$1.8-billion so-called anti-weaponization fund that would have given payments to allies of President Trump. A separate news release also placed limits on tax audit immunity granted to Trump, two of his sons and their businesses.

Those announcements were enough to persuade two holdout Republican lawmakers, Sen. John Cornyn of Texas and Sen. Thom Tillis of North Carolina, on Monday to end their opposition, clearing the biggest obstacle to Blanche’s nomination.

The fund and the immunity were the product of a

settlement from a lawsuit brought by Trump, two of his sons and their businesses against the Internal Revenue Service over the leak of tax documents.

Although the memo appears to have cleared the immediate hurdles Blanche faced for his confirmation, critics of the deal expressed doubts about whether it really is dead.

“These assurances are not worth the paper they’re written on. They don’t pull back on the ongoing attempts to give the President, his family, and his affiliates unauthorized immunity from tax audits,” said Brandon DeBot, policy director of the Tax Law Center at NYU Law.

Trump continued to express support for the fund Sunday, saying that it would reimburse people charged in connection with the Jan. 6, 2021 storming of the U.S. Capitol “for the pain they suffered.”

“A lot of people like it,” Trump said.

The terms of the settlement had become a sticking point for Cornyn and Tillis, whose support in the Senate Judiciary Committee was

[See **Blanche**, A6]

Homes built better but more still burn

Percentage surviving California wildfires is dropping despite the effort to harden them.

By NOAH HAGGERTY

At the turn of the century, wildfires destroyed only about 3% of the California homes they came into contact with. By 2020, the rate had risen to 18%, according to a new study from UC Merced.

It’s an indication that decades of efforts to clear flammable plants around homes and fortify their exteriors against flames, heat and embers are being outpaced by increasingly extreme wildfire behavior and construction in fire-prone areas.

“Fires will continue to grow, because climate change has already occurred,” said Mukesh Kumar, a postdoctoral scientist who led the study. “The encouraging message is that we have identified the factors associated with higher survivability — even in Cali-

fornia.”

While the entire American West experienced a decrease in the percentage of homes surviving wildfires, California had a particularly pronounced drop. The findings add to a growing body of research showing the rising number of destroyed homes across the western U.S. is driven not only by wildfires reaching more properties, but also by homes faring worse when wildfires reach them.

“That’s really kind of disheartening — that we’ve tried our best to mitigate fires ... yet fires are destroying more homes,” said Amanda Carlson, a research scientist with the U.S. Geological Survey who was not involved in the study but has found similar drops in the percentage of homes surviving in much of the American West.

California has taken significant steps to increase the odds of homes surviving wildfires in recent decades, in response to increasingly destructive wildfires fueled partly by global warming and a history of forest mis-

[See **Homes**, A6]

This marmot study’s got money troubles

Looking for some marmot content? Try OnlyFans or, rather, OnlyMarms.

Researchers at a UCLA-affiliated marmot research lab launched an OnlyFans account to post videos of marmots captured in the wild as a way to help generate funding for their work and offset federal cuts to universities.

Since it debuted at the end of May, the account known as “OnlyMarms” has posted several dozen videos. In one, a female marmot known as “1” chases away a curious male named “G” as he pokes around her burrow, screeching as they go.

In another, a marmot eyes the game camera, getting closer and closer to the lens.

“These are wild animals, so it’s important for people to know that we are just getting footage of them in their natural environment,” said Emily Renkey, a first-year

To help offset federal funding cuts, UCLA lab turns to OnlyFans

By Samantha Masunaga



DANIEL BLUMSTEIN

MARMOTS caught on video in the wild are the stars of OnlyMarms, which generates funding for the lab.

graduate student in the Blumstein Lab at UCLA. “We’re just framing it as a way to be in the field observing marmots with us.”

Unlike much of the not-suitable-for-work content on OnlyFans, OnlyMarms is G-rated, though an occasional scuffle might make it more PG, said Dan Blumstein, professor of ecology and evolutionary biology at UCLA and co-director of the Marmot Project at the Rocky Mountain Biological Laboratory in Colorado.

Behavioral and physiological ecologist Ken Armitage, who died in 2022, began his marmot research at the Rocky Mountain lab in 1962. His study of the yellow-bellied marmot remains one of the longest-running studies of its kind. Blumstein assumed responsibility for the project in 2001 when Armitage retired.

Blumstein came up with

[See **OnlyMarms**, A6]



JUSTIN CASTERLINE Getty Images

RIVALRY BACK ON

USC will resume its football series with Notre Dame in 2030 after the Trojans held firm on a demand for an early-season date. **SPORTS, B10**

‘Last chance’ for Iran, Trump says

The latest talks to forge a deal and avoid an escalation of strikes are to take place in the next day or two. **WORLD, A3**

Weather

Mostly sunny, warm. L.A. Basin: 88/67. **B6**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

California sues federal agencies

Two lawsuits seek to block Trump’s latest tariffs and data sharing with ICE. **NATION, A4**

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